NOXIOUS DISTINCTION

- As per the World Air Quality Report 2021, India has **10 of the world's top 15 most polluted places** and another 53 in the top 100



- No city in India has met the WHO air quality guideline of 5 µg/m3. In 2021, **48 per cent of India's cities exceeded 50 µg/m3**, or over 10 times the WHO guideline
- Air pollution was responsible for 1.67 million deaths in 2019 or **17.8 per cent of all deaths in India** (2019), says the Lancet Planetary Health Report
- Water pollution was responsible for **1.4 million deaths** and lead pollution caused 900,000 premature deaths, says the report
- Between 2000 and 2019, economic losses caused by pollution are estimated to be **1 per cent of India's GDP**

WHAT NEEDS TO BE DONE

- Develop adequate infrastructure for treating 40 million litres of wastewater entering rivers and other water bodies
- Build water treatment plants that rely on techniques such as flocculation, skimming and filtration to remove toxic chemicals
- Promote water conservation and industrial water reuse
- Diffuse the irrigation-centric national water policy that allows 85 per cent of India's fresh water to be used for farming
- Minimise flow of collected wastes to landfills, now at a staggering 77 per cent, by increasing recycling from the current five per cent
- Enforce ban on the manufacture, sale, distribution and use of single-use plastics, in place from July 1, 2022

MILESTONES

1972
National Council for Environmental Policy and Planning formed within department of science and technology following the UN conference on human environment in Stockholm

1974
Water (prevention and control of pollution) Act passed

1976
Article 48(A) of Constitution mentions protection of environment as a directive principle; Article 51-A (g) mentions it as a fundamental duty

1981
Air (prevention and control of pollution) Act passed

1986
In the wake of the December 1984 Bhopal gas tragedy, the comprehensive **Environment (Protection) Act is passed**. National Coastal Zone Management Authority set up, later converted as the National Ganga Council

2000
Deadlines set for **phasing out of various ODSes** (ozone-depleting substances)

2005
SC rules "freedom from noise pollution is part of the right to life under Article 21"

2018
Coastal regulation zones notified to promote sustainable development while taking into account increasing sea levels

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

